India's continuing refusal to sign the NPT would lead to friction with the US. Haksar, however, caustically described the treaty as "born out of … a facile assumption that if you put a lid on a boiling cauldron, it magically stops boiling."[237] As far as Indian policymakers were concerned, not only were the superpowers not moving toward disarmament, but, in the meantime, as Indian diplomat Arthur Lall later put it, China was also "merrily exploding nuclear weapons."[238] The NPT had emerged from a "coincidence of interest between [the] USSR and [the] USA," but it was not in India's interest. Lacking steps toward disarmament, the treaty would not "add to the sense of security in the world." Two of the five nuclear powers were not even signing it:

> This might not have mattered but for the fact that one of the non-signatories is our neighbour, namely, China, who is full of hostile intentions towards our country. It is not subject to the discipline which arises from membership of the United Nations; it accepts no generally accepted norms of international behaviour and accepts no restraint. It is imbued with an ideology which seeks to interfere in the affairs of the other countries.[239]

Years earlier, Nehru had told Eisenhower and Khrushchev that no disarmament attempt would be effective if it excluded China.[240] Even before the Sino-Soviet split had become evident, India had been concerned that a China that was left out of the international system and that developed "sophisticated weapons" would not even be subject to restraint from Moscow.[241] Now with strained relations with both superpowers, China was still outside the international system and thus potentially dangerous. Thus, while India's representatives in the NPT discussions in spring 1968 had instructions not to underplay or overplay the Chinese nuclear threat, that threat—and the need to keep India's nuclear option open—led to India's decision not to sign the treaty.[242] Delhi could not foreclose any option that could help it deal with the threats it faced.

The China Option?

Delhi even considered mitigating the China threat by reaching out to Beijing. The desire to reduce dependence—and prepare for a change in the superpowers' relations with China—led to internal discussions about a